

Echoes of Violence

Documenting International Human Rights Crimes in Ethiopia

Executive Summary

January 2025



Remnant of a mortar found in southern Tigray, Ethiopia which was used to target houses in March 2021.

Acknowledgments

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Introduction

Ethiopia has experienced prolonged conflict over the past five years that has resulted in significant human suffering and widespread human rights violations. The war in Tigray, erupted in November 2020,¹ after the central government of Ethiopia and the Tigray People's Liberation Front (TPLF) failed to resolve their political differences peacefully. It has been characterized by mass atrocities, including extrajudicial killings, sexual violence, forced displacements, and the deliberate destruction of civilian infrastructure. Ethiopian, international, and United Nations human rights bodies have indicated that these violations may amount to war crimes and crimes against humanity.² The fighting has also involved external actors, most notably Eritrea, whose forces joined the war in support of the Ethiopian government.³ The war's impact on civilians has been underscored by reports of indiscriminate shelling, ethnic-based targeting, and conflict-related sexual violence on a massive scale.⁴

After engulfing Tigray, the war spread to neighboring regions, drawing in regional militias and transforming it into a multi-faceted conflict with devastating humanitarian consequences for millions of civilians.^{5,6} Moreover, the conflict that erupted in 2023 in the Amhara region between federal government forces and regional militia groups [Fano] has continued to ravage the country.⁷ Human rights organizations have highlighted the pervasive culture of impunity surrounding these acts, which has emboldened perpetrators and exacerbated the suffering of victims.⁸

After two years of conflict in Tigray, the parties signed a cessation of hostilities agreement in November 2022 in Pretoria, South Africa.⁹ Despite this agreement, Eritrean forces in Tigray continued to commit rape and other forms of sexual violence in areas they occupied.¹⁰

The United States has declared all parties to the conflict to have committed war crimes and has called for those responsible to be held accountable.¹¹ Yet despite the Ethiopian government's obligation to pursue legitimate mechanisms of justice and accountability for the crimes committed – as stipulated in the peace agreement¹² – justice has been elusive. Experts have raised concerns around the effectiveness of Ethiopia's transitional justice framework, noting that without political will and the engagement of affected communities, these mechanisms risk failing to deliver meaningful outcomes.¹³

Addressing the mass atrocities of the recent past is of immense importance and is necessary to break the cycle of impunity and prevent the crimes now being reported across the country. The Organization for Justice and Accountability in the Horn of Africa (OJAH) has conducted an in-depth investigation into 10 representative incidents that highlight the diverse and serious nature of crimes committed in the region. The findings below underline the urgent need for independent accountability measures.

Methodology

The investigation employed a thorough methodology to impartially and objectively examine allegations of international human rights violations during the conflict in Northern Ethiopia. Ten incidents were purposefully selected as case studies to illustrate a range of crimes and mechanisms of harm perpetrated by various parties to the conflict.

The Organization for Justice and Accountability in Ethiopia (OJAH)'s independent investigators underwent specialized training on international human rights law, advanced interviewing techniques, and evidence triangulation, facilitated by the Syrian Justice and Accountability Centre (SJAC) and independent experts.

The investigation relied on diverse evidence sources, including an extensive archive from OJAH containing witness interviews and post-incident documentation. Open-source materials, such as satellite imagery and reports, were used to corroborate findings. Field investigations conducted by OJAH addressed evidentiary gaps by collecting additional primary data from survivors and witnesses.

Collected evidence was systematically analyzed to detail each incident, focusing on witness narratives. Factual details such as time, location, and victim counts were highlighted, and supported by open-source intelligence. Legal experts analyzed findings within international legal frameworks, linking evidence to relevant legal provisions.

OJAH implemented rigorous measures to ensure the chain of custody for evidence collected and archived during its investigation of the incidents. Standardized protocols were followed to safeguard the integrity of digital materials, including photographs, videos, witness testimonies, and documents. Each item was securely labeled and logged in an encrypted database, with access strictly limited to authorized personnel. Informed consent was obtained from witnesses and survivors, and further measures were taken to ensure their safety, including anonymization of personal details and maintaining data in an archived database with encryption and protected access.

Findings

The investigative findings highlight grave human rights violations committed during the conflict in northern Ethiopia. The 10 case studies reveal a disturbing pattern of targeted atrocities, including mass killings, sexual violence and other forms of torture, and the destruction of civilian infrastructure. Civilians, including men, women, children and the elderly, were systematically targeted through house-to-house searches, indiscriminate attacks, and public executions. The involvement of Eritrean Defense Forces (EDF) and the Ethiopian National Defense Forces (ENDF) is consistently documented, illustrating campaigns of terror and subjugation perpetrated by state agents.

Bora

Bora is the capital of Bora Chelena, a woreda (district) in southern Tigray. On December 31, 2020, the ENDF reportedly began targeting the families of suspected Tigrayan militia members in Bora and detaining 47 civilians, including children and the elderly, in the town school. Survivors reported being threatened, beaten, and interrogated, while children were left abandoned on the streets. The violence continued on January 8-9, 2021, when door-to-door searches escalated into killings. Civilians were accused of hiding weapons or supporting militias, without evidence. Entire families, including children and the elderly, were executed, and homes were looted and destroyed. Witnesses recounted horrific scenes, including mass shootings, torture, and public executions. Some survivors described being shot and left for dead, surrounded by the bodies of their loved ones. Estimates suggest more than 175 civilians were killed,¹⁴ and OJAH was able to confirm 96 deaths and 20 injuries.

In March 2021, Eritrean forces entered Bora and coordinated attacks with the ENDF, using heavy artillery and mortar fire. Churches, homes, and critical infrastructure were severely damaged. Medical records indicate that at least 860 cases of conflict-related sexual violence were reported by survivors, including among children as young as four. Survivors faced limited access to medical care, stigmatization, and long-term health consequences.

Witnesses said the perpetrators appeared intent on crushing local resistance to the ENDF and EDF invasion, punishing civilians, destroying livelihoods, and weakening the Tigrayan community based on the statements they were making while inflicting the injuries. The investigation showed attacks in December 2020 and January 2021 were carried out by the ENDF's 3rd Battalion of the 3rd Brigade, while the incidents in March were allegedly perpetrated by Eritrean forces, whose specific details are not yet known.

Mahbere Dego

Mahbere Dego is a town in Naeder Adet woreda in central Tigray. It is located 12.5 km south of the city of Axum. The Mahbere Dego massacre stands as a harrowing example of extrajudicial killings during the Tigray conflict.¹⁵ The findings detail systematic violence by the ENDF,

including house-to-house searches where soldiers forcibly removed young men accused of supporting the TPLF, took them to the cliffs near Mahbere Dego, executed them, and dumped their bodies into the valley below.

The investigation revealed that the ENDF soldiers not only carried out the killings but also filmed them.¹⁶ Videos later analyzed and verified using geolocation techniques including by CNN and other open source investigators show soldiers wearing the ENDF's uniform and insignia leading groups of unarmed civilians to the cliff's edge, shooting them at close range, and discarding their bodies over the cliffs.¹⁷ Eyewitnesses have confirmed the involvement of ENDF's 25th Division in the massacre.¹⁸

Witnesses recounted how survivors and families were denied access to the site and how artillery attacks targeted those attempting to retrieve remains. Ultimately, locals could only identify their loved ones through personal belongings such as clothing or ID cards, due to the deterioration of the bodies by the time families were able to access them. The remains were buried collectively in nearby churches, where communities gathered to mourn. OJAH has confirmed the names of at least 50 victims, but it believes the actual number of people killed to be higher, as many people are still missing and unaccounted for.

Edaga Berhe

Edaga Berhe is a small village situated in the A'det woreda in central Tigray. Between February 3 and 5, 2021, high-ranking officers of the ENDF's 25th Division allegedly ordered the indiscriminate execution of Tigrayan males in and around Edaga Berhe. House-to-house searches led to the abduction and execution of civilians, including farmers, students, and youth. On February 3, in the nearby town of A'di Hu'tsa, 12 men were taken from their homes; only one survived. Similar atrocities occurred the same day in Enda Enqura'e, another nearby town, where soldiers from the ENDF's 4th Company killed 11 youths. Witnesses reported being denied access to the bodies for several days, leaving them to be mutilated by scavengers.

On February 5 in A'di Gezaei and Wombel Adi, ENDF soldiers executed 23 more civilians. Survivors described brutal killings using firearms and knives, with some soldiers forcing new recruits to participate in the executions.

OJAH has obtained the names of 75 civilians (all male) who were killed in Edaga Berhe and its surrounding areas within three days. The victims ranged from young boys to elderly men, many of whom were breadwinners for their families. Some families lost multiple members. Witness testimonies and video evidence confirm the deliberate targeting of Tigrayans by soldiers speaking Amharic, the ENDF's official language. Survivors and witnesses identified the specific Ethiopian military units and individuals responsible, including members of the 25th Division's 2nd Battalion, 2nd Brigade.

Mierab Abaya Camp Prison

Mierab Abaya is a town in the former Southern Nations, Nationalities and People's Region of Ethiopia. On November 21, 2021, guards opened fire at a prison camp near the town that housed ENDF members of Tigrayan origin who were detained, killing 54 people inside the camp. Survivors recounted soldiers pursuing and executing those trying to hide. Some detainees escaped to nearby forests but faced violence from locals incited by ENDF commanders. Over three days, 83 Tigrayan military prisoners were killed, including 31 outside the camp, while survivors described scenes of brutality, with bodies collected and buried in mass graves. The ENDF's 17th Division (known as the Dejen Division) was stationed at Mierab Abaya military camp and has been implicated in the massacre by several reports ¹⁹.

Mariam Shewito

Mariam Shewito, a district near Adwa in central Tigray, came under a devastating series of attacks by the EDF between October 25 and November 1, 2022. The EDF launched systematic attacks on civilians, which killed 106 people, including 17 women and 89 men, with victims ranging from 3 to 92 years old. Entire families were executed, homes looted and burned, and livelihoods destroyed.

The violence began with house-to-house searches, starting at the home of a 92-year-old man whose seven family members were executed, their home looted and burned. Witnesses described soldiers targeting civilians indiscriminately, accusing them of aiding the Tigrayan forces popularly called Tigray Defense Forces (TDF). Victims included men, women, children, and priests, some killed inside their homes and others dragged out and slaughtered in gorges or nearby water bodies. Soldiers spoke Tigrinya (typically spoken by Eritrean forces), and their rhetoric emphasized collective punishment, branding villagers as TDF supporters.

The EDF's actions extended beyond killings, with homes, food supplies, and livestock systematically destroyed. Survivors recounted soldiers looting cash and property, leaving families destitute. Bodies were denied burial for days, many left exposed to scavengers. Mass graves were later discovered, along with widespread destruction of civilian infrastructure.

Adi Gedena

Adi Gedena, located in Adi Daero woreda near the Eritrean border, holds socio-economic significance as a gold mining site. From October 14 to 17, 2022, the town experienced devastating attacks marked by heavy artillery shelling, looting, and systematic targeting of civilians by the EDF.

Witnesses reported that on October 14, 2022, shelling killed multiple civilians, despite the absence of ongoing hostilities, as the TDF had withdrawn the previous day. Survivors fled to caves and other locations, but some who stayed faced deadly violence, including gunfire targeting fleeing groups. Between October 16 and 17, EDF forces reportedly conducted house-to-house

searches and indiscriminate executions, particularly of elderly residents. Nine men aged 55 to 70 were executed in the May-Gobo and Zban Gereb areas located near Adi Daero.

A survivor described being tortured by EDF soldiers on October 20 after being accused of retaining a weapon. The torture caused life-altering injuries, including paralysis and the amputation of his hand. OJAH confirmed 39 civilian deaths and extensive destruction of homes and property.

The EDF, identified by their uniforms and language, were stationed at a makeshift camp in a bombed warehouse known as Da Dejat Sahle. Witnesses said the violence was intended as collective punishment, allegedly for sheltering Eritrean escapees, based on statements made by the perpetrators.

Maryam Dengelat Church

Between November 30 and December 2, 2020, Eritrean forces perpetrated a brutal massacre at a church in Maryam Dengelat and its vicinities, in northern Tigray. A group of Eritrean soldiers opened fire on Maryam Dengelat church while hundreds were observing an annual Christian holiday. The soldiers also followed and fired at people who tried to flee on foot, scrambling up cliff paths to neighboring villages. Over the next two days, Eritrean soldiers carried out systematic killings, including house-to-house searches, executions of bound victims, and mass shootings of those attempting to escape.

On December 2, the soldiers permitted informal burials, permitting the filling of mass graves with bodies under strict supervision, with soldiers forbidding mourning. Elsewhere, bodies were often left exposed, their location later identified by the presence of vultures circling above. While multiple sources reported more than 160 civilians to have been killed, to date OJAH has confirmed the names of 89 victims. These included Sunday school students, priests, pregnant women, and infants. Many other victims remain unidentified.

Eyewitnesses identified the perpetrators as Eritrean forces based on their language, scars, and uniforms. Survivors refuted claims of Tigrayan fighters being present at the time.

Togoga Market Airstrike

On June 22, 2021, the Ethiopian Air Force conducted an airstrike on the busy market in Togoga, in the southeastern Inderta district of Tigray, killing 64 civilians and injuring 184 others. The attack occurred around 1:00 PM, a peak market hour when thousands of people from surrounding districts had gathered. Witnesses described a sudden explosion, the ensuing chaos, and their return to rescue the injured amidst a scene of complete destruction, with bodies of people and animals intermingled and buildings reduced to rubble. The victims included many children, youth, and elderly people.

The impact of the strike was compounded by Ethiopian soldiers blocking roads into Togoga, preventing ambulances from reaching the injured. Health workers and locals reported that several of the injured died due to the lack of timely medical treatment. Medical records accessed by OJAH confirmed victims ranged in age from 2 to 62 years old, with injuries caused by shrapnel and blast trauma.

Such large-scale attacks have occurred before in this region, most notably on June 22, 1988, when airstrikes by the Derg military dictatorship killed some 2,500 civilians in a market near Togoga.

Mekelle Kindergarten Airstrike

On August 26, 2022, at approximately 12:40 PM, an airstrike struck SOS Kindergarten in Mekelle, the capital of the Tigray region. Witnesses reported hearing a jet flying overhead before three loud explosions rocked the area. The attack directly hit the kindergarten playground and caused extensive damage to nearby residential homes and small business centers. By the time victims were transported to the hospital, four people, including two children, had already succumbed to their injuries.

The airstrike killed seven people and injured at least 10 others. Among the deceased were two boys, aged 6 and 10, who were playing in the playground at the time of the attack. Their sister, a seven-year-old girl, was severely injured. The Ethiopian Air Force is alleged to have carried out the attack, using Su-27 fighter jets. It is the only party in the Ethiopia known to operate fighter jets at the time.²⁰

Dedebit Elementary School Drone Attack

On the night of January 7, 2022, at approximately 11:00 PM, a drone attack targeted Dedebit Elementary School in northwestern Tigray, which was serving as an informal camp for internally displaced persons (IDPs). The attack, occurring on Ethiopian Orthodox Christmas, involved three bombs. The first bomb struck the main school building, which was housing many displaced families, resulting in significant loss of life. As survivors attempted to flee through the main gate, a second bomb struck the escaping crowd, followed by a third explosion within the compound.

The attack killed at least 59 people and injured at least 30 others, including 15 children, the youngest of whom was just one year old. The victims were civilians who had been forcibly displaced from Humera town in western Tigray in November and December 2021. The destruction of the school building and temporary shelters within the structure further compounded the suffering of these vulnerable populations.

Evidence collected at the site confirmed that the bombs²¹ were compatible with Bayraktar TB2 drones, which were being used by the Ethiopian Air Force, the only party in the conflict known to operate armed drones at the time. The drones allowed operators to view their targets in real time, and multiple sources confirmed that no military targets were present in Dedebit, suggesting the strikes were deliberately aimed at civilians.

Legal Analysis

The conflict that began in Ethiopia's Tigray region on 3 November 2020 has been classified by the United Nations International Commission of Human Rights Experts on Ethiopia as a non-international armed conflict ²². This designation, consistent with findings from other United Nations bodies, triggers the applicability of Common Article 3 of the Geneva Conventions and Additional Protocol II, which govern the conduct of parties to non-international armed conflicts. These provisions require the humane treatment of persons not taking part in hostilities and strictly prohibit violence to life and person, cruel treatment, and attacks on civilians and civilian objects.

A legal analysis of the incidents documented in this report reveals grave and widespread violations of both international human rights law and international humanitarian law. The evidence points to a deliberate and systematic pattern of targeting civilians and civilian infrastructure throughout the conflict. Violations include willful killings, torture, inhumane treatment, indiscriminate attacks, pillaging, and the destruction of homes, schools, places of worship, and other protected objects. These acts represent clear breaches of Common Article 3 and Articles 4 and 13 of Additional Protocol II, which prohibit such conduct even during armed conflict.

These violations also contravene international human rights instruments, including the Universal Declaration of Human Rights (Articles 3 and 5), the International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights (Articles 6, 7, and 9), and the African Charter on Human and Peoples' Rights (Article 4), all of which uphold the rights to life, liberty, and protection from torture and cruel, inhuman, or degrading treatment.

While Ethiopia is not party to the Rome Statute²³, the acts documented in this report meet the threshold for war crimes and crimes against humanity under the Rome Statute of the International Criminal Court (ICC). War crimes committed include: murder, cruel treatment, and torture (Article 8(2)(c)(i)); outrages upon personal dignity (Article 8(2)(c)(ii)); sentencing or execution without due process (Article 8(2)(c)(iv)); attacks against civilians (Article 8(2)(e)(i)); attacks on protected objects (Article 8(2)(e)(iv)); pillaging (Article 8(2)(e)(v)); and the war crime of rape (Article 8(2)(e)(vi)-1). The evidence also supports the commission of crimes against humanity, including murder (Article 7(1)(a)), torture (Article 7(1)(f)), and rape (Article 7(1)(g)-1), carried out as part of a widespread or systematic attack on the civilian population.

These violations were often perpetrated against vulnerable populations, including women, children, and the elderly. The consistent pattern of targeting a specific ethnic group, the intentional destruction of critical civilian infrastructure and food supplies, and the denial of burials and mourning rites underscore the calculated nature and severity of the atrocities. Collectively, these findings demonstrate a profound and deliberate disregard for international legal norms and obligations, warranting urgent accountability and redress.

Conclusion

The incidents detailed in this report, depicting grim instances where even kindergartens and religious grounds were attacked, represent only a fraction of the immense devastation caused by the conflict in northern Ethiopia. However, they provide critical insight into the widespread and grave nature of the atrocities, the profound human toll of the war, and the actions and intentions of the perpetrators. These incidents reveal a pattern of systematic violence, the targeting of civilians through indiscriminate killings, sexual violence and other forms of torture, and the destruction of livelihoods and critical infrastructure. Perpetrators, including Eritrean Defense Forces (EDF) and Ethiopian National Defense Forces (ENDF), engaged in

acts of collective punishment, often with the intent of subjugating and terrorizing communities. Evidence from witness testimonies, open-source intelligence, and field investigations underscores the widespread and deliberate nature of these crimes. The use of advanced weaponry, such as drones, and the involvement of foreign forces further exacerbated the suffering of civilians. In many cases, the targeting of vulnerable populations, including women, children, and the elderly, reflects a deliberate strategy to erode the social and economic fabric of affected communities.

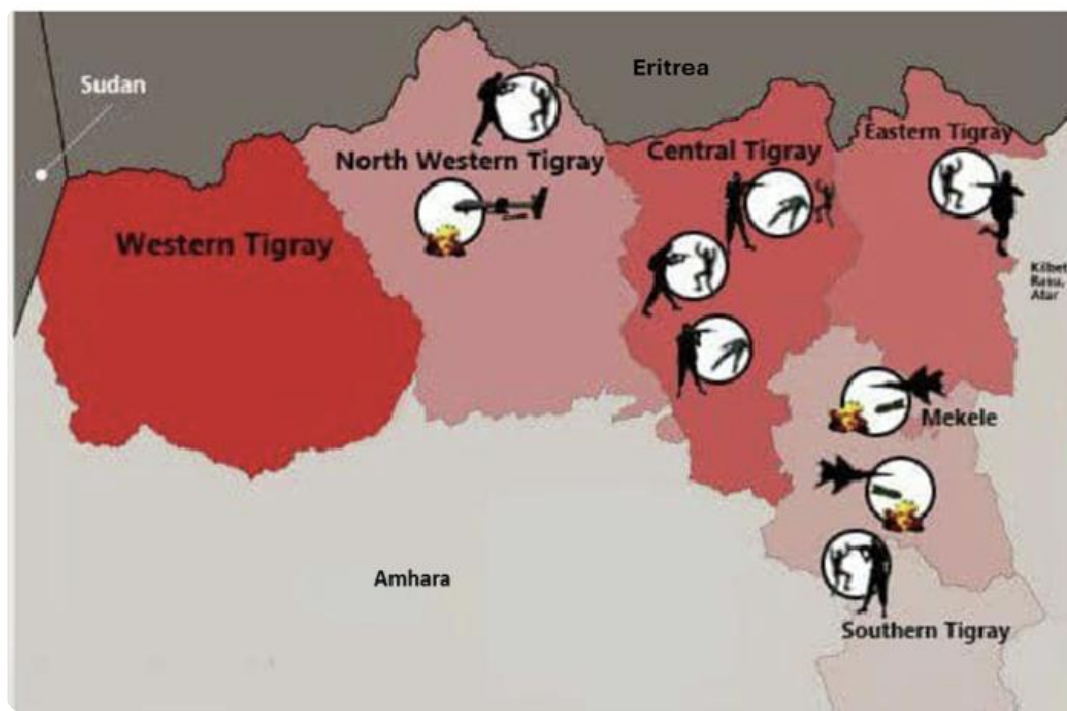


Figure 1: Image shows locations and types of attacks

Recommendations

In the absence of international justice mechanisms, the Ethiopian government has assumed the position of sole investigator and adjudicator for the crimes of the recent past. However, the engagement of Ethiopian federal and regional forces in the conflict, as well as the involvement of Eritrean Defense Forces, point to the insufficiency of the local transitional justice mechanisms in ensuring accountability.

To the Government of Ethiopia:

- Ensure the meaningful and safe involvement of victims, civil society, and marginalized groups in transitional justice mechanisms and implement independent monitoring to improve transparency and credibility throughout the process.

To the International Community:

- Establish and support independent investigative mechanisms to document human rights violations and hold perpetrators accountable.
- Prioritize ongoing efforts to monitor, document, and report human rights violations across Ethiopia to maintain accountability and prevent further atrocities.
- Encourage and support countries with universal jurisdiction laws to pursue the prosecution of perpetrators in their national courts to ensure justice for international crimes.

To the United Nations Security Council:

- Refer the situation in Ethiopia to the International Criminal Court (ICC) for investigation and prosecution of the perpetrators.

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